and 160 kbps files against each other, my co-workers had a much more difficult time finding differences in the sound quality. Apparently, given the limitations of a computer-and-headphones listening environment, the differences between high-bitrate sound files and uncompressed audio are too subtle for most listeners to easily notice. Still, the high-bitrate AAC file was clearly preferred over its MP3 and WMA counterparts—a testament to AAC's effectiveness.

"WMA performed well, too, edging out AAC at the lower bitrate. (It was interesting) to find that the 64 kbps WMA file received the exact same average rating as the high-bitrate MP3 file. So, would my co-workers who listen to 128 kbps MP3s be just as happy with their music's sound quality if they saved it in WMA format, in a file taking up half the hard drive space? It appears so—although it's important to note that results may vary depending on the genre of music they're listening to, as well as the encoding software they use to compress the music."